



Coral

△ Red coral from the Mediterranean sea

Precious (red) coral includes species such as *Corallium rubrum* and *Corallium japonicum* and is found in tropical and semi-tropical waters.

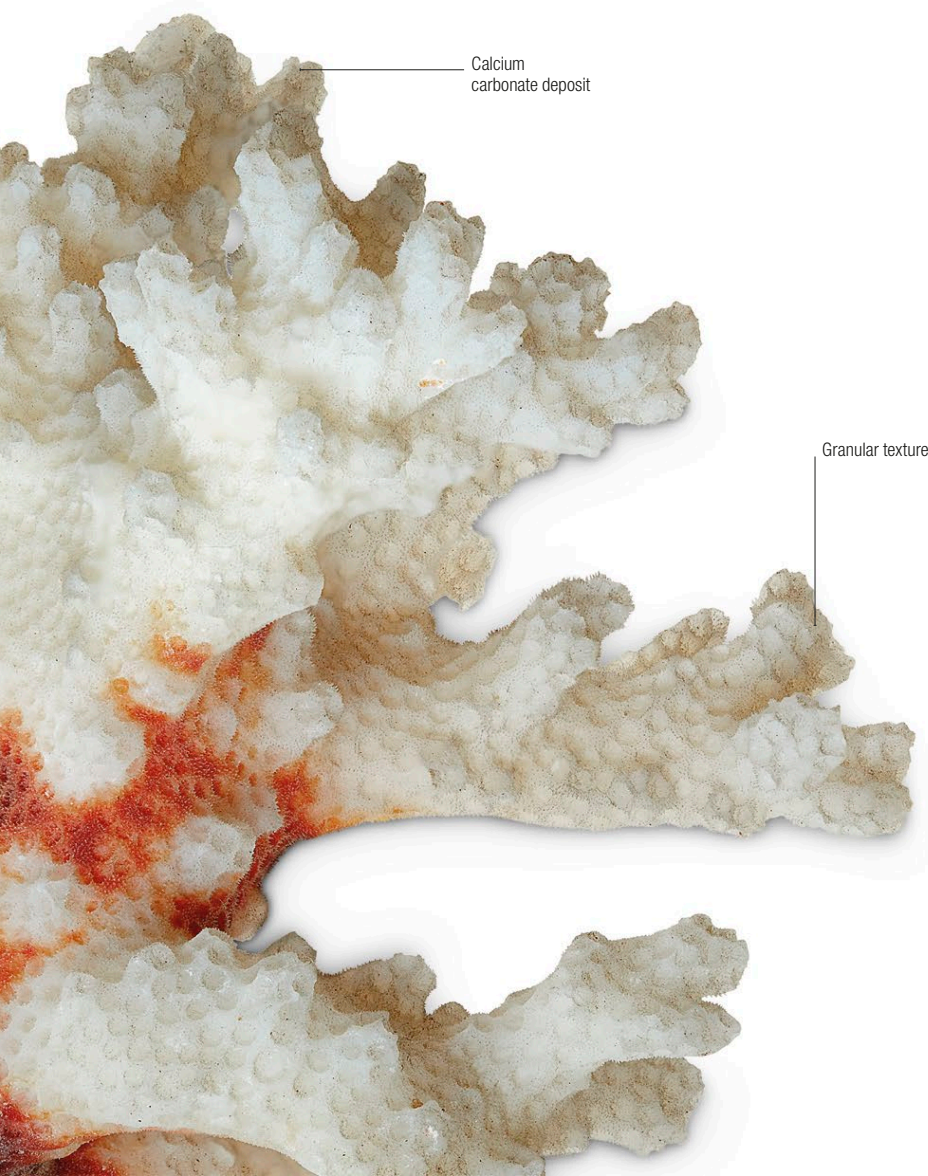
Precious coral is valued over other types of coral for its toughness and attractive pink to red hues. Coral is the exoskeleton of the marine polyp – a small creature that secretes calcium carbonate to form branchlike structures. As the branches tend to be fine and narrow, material is usually sourced from the thicker forks. Coral has been used decoratively since prehistoric times.

Specification

Chemical name Calcium carbonate | **Formula** CaCO_3
Colours Pale pink (angelskin), orange, red | **Structure** Crystalline
Hardness 3.5 | **SG** 2.6–2.7 | **RI** 1.48–1.66 | **Lustre** Vitreous, waxy | **Streak** White | **Locations** Warm seas around Japan and Malaysia, Mediterranean, African coastal waters

Rough

Natural coral | The sections of coral most useful to jewellers are the thickest parts where two branches meet, or the widest part of a limb. The scale is often small – this piece of raw coral is about 6cm (2¼in) in width.



Polished surface



Red coral slice | This coral cross-section reveals the intricate, banded structure of the material. The lustre is dull when harvested, but polishing makes it shine.

Cut

High polish gives vitreous lustre



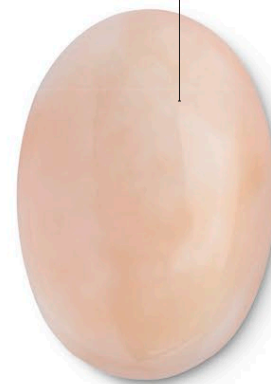
Coral oblong cabochon | Because it is soft and opaque, coral is often cut *en cabochon*. Then it can be polished and the colour shown off to its advantage.

Wood-grain pattern



Branch of red coral | The longitudinal striations (grooves) give this natural piece of uncut coral a typical pattern that resembles natural wood grain.

Smooth gloss shows off colour



Oval cabochon | The simple shape and cut emphasize the colour of this cabochon, often referred to as “angelskin”, a term that can apply to hues from pale pink to salmon.